

Daily Content Intel

August 25, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, researchers pulled 2 years of national survey data on high school athletes, and the average came back at 6 hours and 34 minutes of sleep a night.

The recommendation for that age is 8 to 10 hours. So your average high school athlete is running close to a 2 hour deficit every night, all season long.

The concussion piece is what got my attention. Athletes reporting one concussion slept less than athletes reporting none, and athletes with 2 or more slept less still. That's a dose-response pattern, and it held after they adjusted for age and sex and the rest of it.

I want to be straight about what this is, though. It's a snapshot in time, so it can't tell you which one came first, and the size of the gap is small, a matter of minutes. The authors say that themselves.

It still points at something I'll say without hedging. Sleep is the cheapest recovery tool your athlete has, and it's the first one they cut.

So this week, count the hours before you buy anything. Pick a phone-down time, back the wake-up out from there, and defend it like a lift.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Researchers counted how much sleep high school athletes actually get. It's 6 hours and 34 minutes.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, researchers pulled 2 years of national survey data on high school athletes, and the

average came back at 6 hours and 34 minutes of sleep a night.

The recommendation for that age is 8 to 10 hours. So your average high school athlete is running close to a 2 hour deficit every night, all season long.

The concussion piece is what got my attention. Athletes reporting one concussion slept less than athletes reporting none, and athletes with 2 or more slept less still. That's a dose-response pattern, and it held after they adjusted for age and sex and the rest of it.

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It still points at something I'll say without hedging. Sleep is the cheapest recovery tool your athlete has, and it's the first one they cut.

So this week, count the hours before you buy anything. Pick a phone-down time, back the

wake-up out from there, and defend it like a lift.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 6 hours, 34 minutes
- 0:08 That's the national average for a high school athlete
- 0:15 Recommended: 8 to 10 hours
- 0:28 1 concussion = less sleep. 2 or more = less still.
- 0:45 Snapshot data. Direction unknown.
- 0:58 Sleep is the cheapest thing on the list
- 1:10 Count the hours before you buy anything

Caption (copy-paste ready):

6 hours and 34 minutes. That's the average night of sleep for a US high school athlete, pulled from 2 years of national survey data.

The recommendation for that age is 8 to 10.

The same study found a dose-response pattern with concussion history: athletes

reporting one concussion slept less than athletes reporting none, and athletes with 2 or more slept less still. It's cross-sectional, so it can't tell you which came first, and the gaps are minutes rather than hours. The authors are clear about that.

The training takeaway doesn't need the causal arrow. Sleep is the cheapest recovery tool an athlete has and it's the first one to get cut in season.

Count the hours before you buy a single recovery gadget. Pick a phone-down time, back the wake-up out from there, and defend it like a lift.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Dr. Lars Stevenson, PT, DPT
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#highschoolfootball #lacrosse
#athletedevelopment #sportsrecovery
#strengthandconditioning #youthsports
#sleep #athletictraining #sportsPT
#returntosport #nova #restonva

Personalize this

- Which of your HS football or lacrosse athletes actually knows their bedtime, and what does the honest number look like for the ones lifting at 6am before school?
- When you build in-season vs offseason blocks, do you write sleep into the program the way you write the lifts, or does it live in the "we talked about it" pile?
- Where does sleep sit in your CROSS framework conversation with a parent, and have you ever pulled load off an athlete purely because their sleep collapsed?

Shoot notes:

- Open standing still, already mid-breath, with the number out of your mouth in the first second. The brief's biggest leak is a mid-sentence cold open, so start on "6 hours and 34 minutes," not on a wind-up into it.
- Shoot against the plain wall, not the gym windows. Two of the three logged drop-offs had gym equipment and large windows pulling attention off you.

- Frame tight, chest up, with the top of your head near the top of the frame. Dead ceiling space above the head shows up in the drop-off vision notes twice. Energy one notch above conversational for the first 8 seconds.

Hook shape: Story hook. Justified by the brief line "A story hook is skipped 3.2 points less than your average across 4 reels," with the payoff placed in the opening clause per "Put the payoff in the first line, not after a wind-up."

Screenshots:

- title |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42627169/>
| "Associations between sleep disturbances and concussions in US high school athletes"
- physiology |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42627169/>
| "High school athletes averaged 6.56 h of sleep per night"
- actionable |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42627169/>
| "A dose-response association was

observed between the self-reported concussion history and the shorter self-reported sleep duration among high school athletes"

Sources:

- <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42627169/>
- <https://doi.org/10.1515/jom-2026-0002>

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, this one is going to annoy some people.

22 guys played a simulated football match, and then got either cold water immersion or hot water immersion, straight after, again at 24 hours, and again at 48.

Researchers tracked them for 3 full days. Quad strength, nerve stimulation to separate the brain side of fatigue from the muscle side, sprint power, and soreness.

The match did what a match does. Voluntary contraction dropped 7%, sprint power dropped almost 9% at the 24 hour mark, and soreness climbed for 2 days.

And the two treatments came out the same on every variable they measured.

The authors' own conclusion is that a hot bath is a practical alternative to the cold.

Here's my read. Cold is doing something, it's just a lot smaller than what the cold tub companies are selling, and if a hot bath gets your kid to the same place by Monday, that's the answer, because it's in your house already and it costs nothing.

It's 22 guys and a simulated match, so hold it loosely. I'd still take that trade.

The boring stuff is still what moves the needle. Sleep, food, and an actual plan for the 48 hours after a game.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Ice bath or hot bath after a football match, and 3 days later, there was no difference between them.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, this one is going to annoy some people.

22 guys played a simulated football match, and then got either cold water immersion or hot water immersion, straight after, again at 24 hours, and again at 48.

Researchers tracked them for 3 full days. Quad strength, nerve stimulation to separate the brain side of fatigue from the muscle side, sprint power, and soreness.

The match did what a match does. Voluntary contraction dropped 7%, sprint power dropped almost 9% at the 24 hour mark, and soreness climbed for 2 days.

And the two treatments came out the same on every variable they measured. The authors' own conclusion is that a hot bath is a practical alternative to the cold.

Here's my read. Cold is doing something, it's just a lot smaller than what the cold tub companies are selling, and if a hot bath gets your kid to the same place by Monday, that's the answer, because it's in your house already and it costs nothing.

It's 22 guys and a simulated match, so hold it loosely. I'd still take that trade.

The boring stuff is still what moves the needle. Sleep, food, and an actual plan for the 48 hours after a game.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 Cold plunge vs hot bath, after a football match
- 0:10 Immersion at 0h, 24h, 48h
- 0:22 Tracked for 72 hours
- 0:32 Sprint power down 8.9% at 24h
- 0:45 Same result. Every variable.
- 1:00 What you're buying with cold is the habit
- 1:15 Sleep. Food. A plan for the 48 hours after.

Caption (copy-paste ready):

22 men played a simulated football match, then went into either cold water immersion or hot water immersion, straight after, again at 24 hours, and again at 48.

Researchers tracked them for 3 days: quad strength, femoral nerve stimulation to split central from peripheral fatigue, sprint force and velocity, and soreness.

The match did its damage. Maximal voluntary contraction dropped 7%, sprint power dropped 8.9% at 24 hours, soreness climbed through 48.

Cold and hot came out the same on every variable. The authors conclude that hot water immersion is a practical, effective alternative to cold.

My read: cold is doing something, it's just smaller than what the cold tub market is selling. If a hot bath gets your athlete to the same place by Monday, take it. It's already in your house.

It's 22 guys and a simulated match, so hold it loosely. I'd still take the trade.

Sleep, food, and an actual plan for the 48 hours after a game are still what move the needle.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

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#coldplunge #icebath #recovery
#highschoolfootball #lacrosse
#strengthandconditioning #sportsrecovery
#athletedevelopment #sportsscience
#sportsPT #nova #restonva

Personalize this

- What are your HS football guys actually doing Saturday morning after a Friday game, and how many of them (or their parents) have bought into a cold tub this year?
- Have you ever run heat instead of cold with a late-stage post-op athlete or a lacrosse player in a congested week, and what did you see in their Monday session?
- When a parent asks you what recovery gear to buy, what's your actual ranking, and where does the CROSS framework put money that isn't sleep and food?

Shoot notes:

- This one lives or dies on energy. The drop-off notes flag "low energy, flat expression" three separate times, so deliver the hook with a bit of an edge on your face, because the take is a challenge and it should look like one.
- Stand somewhere clean and neutral, away from windows and racks. A busy gym background competing with you is the single most repeated leak in the brief.
- No wind-up into the study. First words are the finding, then back into the setup. Do a couple of takes where you start with the sentence already moving.

Hook shape: Story hook. Justified by the brief line "Story hook: 60.9% (-3.2pp vs average, n=4)," the lowest skip rate of any opener shape, with the claim itself carried in the opening line per "open with the claim instead of the setup."

Screenshots:

- title | <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42633554/> | "No differences between cold and hot water immersion for neuromuscular

recovery, sprint mechanics and delayed onset muscle soreness after a simulated football game"

- physiology |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42633554/>
| "No significant differences were found between CWI and HWI for any of these variables during recovery"
- actionable |
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42633554/>
| "These findings suggest that HWI may represent a practical and effective alternative to CWI to restore neuromuscular function, sprint mechanics and perceptual responses"

Sources:

- <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/42633554/>
- <https://doi.org/10.1080/02640414.2026.2713869>

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Competitive level is associated with dietary practices but not sports nutrition knowledge in collegiate athletes (BMC Sports Sci Med Rehabil, PMID 42625223): elite and amateur scored the same on nutrition knowledge, what separated them was what they actually ate, protein intake in particular. Strong "knowing isn't doing" fueling angle.
- Upper-Body Isometric Strength Qualities Are Associated With Faster High-Intensity Running Performances in Professional Soccer Players (JSCR, PMID 42628105): argument against skipping upper body in a speed block.
- Low reliability and high redundancy in inter-limb asymmetry (Human Movement Science, PMID 42636714): the limb symmetry numbers used to clear athletes may be noisier than the people quoting them think. Hot take, needs a careful read first.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest 2026-08-25 (~/Cowork/newsletter-digest/output/newsletter_digest_2026-08-25.pdf): 2 sources, both unusable. Mercola issue was product promo (hyaluronic acid, NAC). Mike T. Nelson issue was a psychedelics/PhD-career interview, off-topic for the athlete audience. No clinical finding pulled from the digest today.
- PubMed, date-filtered 2026-08-16 to 2026-08-25, athlete/football/soccer/lacrosse crossed with strength, sprint, jump, injury: 26 results reviewed.
- PubMed, date-filtered 2026-08-16 to 2026-08-25, adolescent/youth/high school/collegiate athlete crossed with training, recovery, nutrition, sleep, return to sport: 32 results reviewed.
- Direct abstract pulls via NCBI eutils for 4 finalists (PMIDs 42623821, 42633554, 42627169, 42625223). WebFetch on pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov returned a

cookie wall today; eutils was used instead.

- Candidate rejected on brand rules: "Importance of Maximal Force for Modulating Landing Forces" (JSCR, PMID 42623821). Strong finding, but the whole paper is force-plate derived (vGRF, isometric midthigh pull), and Voice DNA bans force plates.
- Content brief ~/Code/Social Media/content-brief.md regenerated 2026-08-25T04:42Z, 2 hours old. Used.
- Note: no daily intel run on 2026-08-22. Gap in the output folder between 08-21 and today.